

The Venetians were hard-headed, profit-conscious merchants and manufacturers. All things considered, they faced far more risks and problems in their day-to-day operations than any modern businessman. Nevertheless, these were the men who were responsible for the building

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of the Doges\* Palace, the Golden Basilica of St. Mark, the great *palazzi* along the Grand Canal and uncounted other magnificent structures which they filled with works of incomparable beauty.

It was in and for "commercial" Venice that Tintoretto, Titian, Veronese and many other masters produced then-greatest works. The canal-laced city of tough-skinned merchants and manufacturers became an artistic wonder of the world—and so it remains even to this day. The beauty and esthetic grandeur of Venice have endured—monuments not only to the artists who created the beauty, but also to the businessmen at whose behest it was created.

In modern times, cultural progress has certainly kept pace with industrial and commercial expansion in such nations as England, France, Italy and Sweden—to name only a few. Neither businessmen nor the populace as a whole in any of these countries is taking any less interest in cultural activities today than they did years, decades or generations ago. Quite to the contrary. It is evident that, although their lives have grown more complex and their pace of living has been greatly accelerated, they are still packing the art galleries, museums, concert halls, theaters and opera houses.

These people have learned a lesson it would be well for many Americans to study. They have learned that culture bestows many rewards and benefits—among them a better, more satisfactory life, great inner satisfaction and mental and emotional refreshment and inspiration.

Americans traveling abroad are often startled to hear rubbish collectors or street sweepers singing operatic arias or humming the themes of symphonies or concertos as they go about their work. If they happen to know the language of the country they are visiting, American tourists are even